

Primary Source Reading 2: The Euthyphro Dilemma

Optima Academy Online | Philosophy & Ethics | High School Honors (9–12) From Plato's Euthyphro, translated by Benjamin Jowett Read before Lesson 2c: The Euthyphro Dilemma

Before you read: Euthyphro's first two definitions of piety have failed. To rescue his position, Socrates himself proposes a repair: instead of "what the gods love" (which breaks down because the gods disagree), why not say piety is what *all* the gods love, without exception? Euthyphro accepts this gladly. But Socrates is not finished — he is about to ask a single question that will outlast the dialogue itself. As you read, follow the logic of the analogy Socrates builds (carrying and being carried, seeing and being seen) and watch what it does to Euthyphro's revised definition.

A Revised Definition

SOCRATES: I will amend the definition so far as to say that what all the gods hate is impious, and what they love pious or holy; and what some of them love and others hate is both or neither. Shall this be our definition of piety and impiety?

EUTHYPHRO: Why not, Socrates?

SOCRATES: Why not, certainly, as far as I am concerned. But whether this admission will greatly assist you in the task of instructing me, is a matter for you to consider.

EUTHYPHRO: Yes, I should say that what all the gods love is pious and holy, and the opposite which they all hate, impious.

SOCRATES: Ought we to enquire into the truth of this, Euthyphro, or simply to accept the mere statement on our own authority?

EUTHYPHRO: We should enquire; and I believe that the statement will stand the test of enquiry. (9d–9e)

The Question

SOCRATES: We shall know better, my good friend, in a little while. The point which I should first wish to understand is whether the pious or holy is beloved by the gods because it is holy, or holy because it is beloved of the gods.

EUTHYPHRO: I do not understand your meaning, Socrates. (10a)

Leading and Being Led

SOCRATES: I will endeavour to explain: we speak of carrying and we speak of being carried, of leading and being led, seeing and being seen. You know that in all such cases there is a difference, and you know also in what the difference lies?

EUTHYPHRO: I think that I understand.

SOCRATES: And is not that which is beloved distinct from that which loves?

EUTHYPHRO: Certainly.

SOCRATES: Well; and now tell me, is that which is carried in this state of carrying because it is carried, or for some other reason?

EUTHYPHRO: No; that is the reason.

SOCRATES: And a thing is not seen because it is visible, but conversely, visible because it is seen; nor is a thing led because it is in the state of being led, or carried because it is in the state of being carried, but the converse of this. My meaning is, that any state of action or passion implies a previous action or passion. It does not become because it is becoming, but it is in a state of becoming because it becomes. Do you not agree?

EUTHYPHRO: Yes. (10a-c)

Applying the Test to Piety

SOCRATES: Is not that which is loved in some state either of becoming or suffering?

EUTHYPHRO: Yes.

SOCRATES: And the same holds as in the previous instances; the state of being loved follows the act of being loved, and not the act the state... And what do you say of piety, Euthyphro: is not piety, according to your definition, loved by all the gods?

EUTHYPHRO: Yes.

SOCRATES: Because it is pious or holy, or for some other reason?

EUTHYPHRO: No, that is the reason.

SOCRATES: It is loved because it is holy, not holy because it is loved?

EUTHYPHRO: Yes.

SOCRATES: And that which is dear to the gods is loved by them, and is in a state to be loved of them because it is loved of them?

EUTHYPHRO: Certainly.

SOCRATES: Then that which is dear to the gods, Euthyphro, is not holy, nor is that which is holy loved of God, as you affirm; but they are two different things.

EUTHYPHRO: How do you mean, Socrates? (10c-e)

Essence, Not Attribute

SOCRATES: I mean to say that the holy has been acknowledged by us to be loved of God because it is holy, not to be holy because it is loved. But that which is dear to the gods is dear to them because it is loved by them, not loved by them because it is dear to them.

EUTHYPHRO: True.

SOCRATES: But, friend Euthyphro, if that which is holy is the same with that which is dear to God, and is loved because it is holy, then that which is dear to God would have been loved as being dear to God; but if that which is dear to God is dear to him

because loved by him, then that which is holy would have been holy because loved by him. But now you see that the reverse is the case, and that they are quite different from one another. For one is of a kind to be loved because it is loved, and the other is loved because it is of a kind to be loved. Thus you appear to me, Euthyphro, when I ask you what is the essence of holiness, to offer an attribute only, and not the essence — the attribute of being loved by all the gods. But you still refuse to explain to me the nature of holiness. (10e–11a)

After you read: Socrates has not yet used the word “dilemma,” but the two possibilities are now on the table: either the pious is loved by the gods *because* it is pious, or it is pious *because* the gods love it — and Socrates has just shown that these are not the same claim. Hold onto both options as you move into the lesson. Each one, taken seriously, turns out to carry a cost that a thoughtful person, believer or not, has to reckon with.